



County of Fairfax, Virginia

MEMORANDUM

December 5, 2025

TO: Bryan Hill
County Executive

FROM: Sean Rastatter, Chairman 
Information Technology Policy Advisory Committee (ITPAC)

SUBJECT: FY 2027 ITPAC Interim Budget Letter to the County Executive

Fairfax County is consistently recognized as a top-performing innovative county with first-class IT management. Thus, expectations are elevated for DIT to deliver exceptional IT-based citizen services and staff support using innovative technology solutions with cost-effective IT investments.

To support this goal, the County set up the Information Technology Policy Advisory Committee (ITPAC) comprised of citizens with significant government and IT industry expertise. Through regular consultations with senior leadership of the Department of Information Technology (DIT), members provide advice for tackling IT challenges and seizing opportunities using modern technologies and methods.

For the FY 2027 budget process, all County agencies have been asked to submit a 5% reduction plan. While reductions may not become part of the final budget, it is crucial that IT be spared, facing reductions as a last resort. Technology investments are critical to achieving savings in other budget areas and may mean further IT savings over time. Also, there are pressing community needs with technology-related requirements. In fact, ITPAC knows it is essential to strengthen IT investments during times of fiscal stress.

County Successes: ITPAC understands that IT operation and leadership are County strengths.

DIT Earns National IT Best Practice Awards: The County's IT Program has often been recognized as a national benchmark for excellence. It is praised for its governance, investments, and low-risk delivery model. It creates cost-effective technology solutions aligned with the Board's goals. In 2025, Fairfax County received second place in the Center for Digital Government's Digital Counties Survey for jurisdictions with populations exceeding 1 million. In the last three years, the County has placed first or second each year. The survey honors the innovative use of emerging technologies, enhanced cybersecurity measures, and strengthened digital equity initiatives. This reflects a citizen and business community with high expectations for the County's commitment to effective technology use. Sustaining this success will require ongoing, consistent technology investments.

Tax System Upgrades: As noted in the recent Board IT committee meeting, technology upgrades have been created to facilitate the food and beverage tax being implemented effective January 1, 2026. From a technology perspective, a new online and backend solution had to be developed to support the collection, reporting and management of the tax. This technical achievement will contribute substantially to a streamlined customer experience.

Department Reorganization: DIT is undergoing significant reorganization as part of a thoughtful, long-term vision to enhance services to residents and prepare the department to be a leader in the rapidly evolving digital landscape. This reorganization is in the early execution phase and ITPAC fully endorses and embraces this important change.

Efficiency and Effectiveness Investment Recommendations: ITPAC endorses the following investments, which are essential to ensuring the reliability, scalability, and efficiency of County IT.

- **Cyber Security Strengthening:** Cyber threats are on the rise. Nationwide, local and state government entities have become prime targets. In today's highly connected digital world, it is essential for maintaining business operation and public safety to safeguard critical infrastructure, manage third-party risks, oversee artificial intelligence (AI) and handle data governance needs. Continuous service delivery of water supply systems, transportation networks, and communication systems require defending this infrastructure from the devastating effects of cyber attacks. Investing in cybersecurity technologies, skilled personnel, and expertise is crucial to protect data and mitigate operational risks.
- **Bringing IT towards its Optimal State:** ITPAC is thrilled that an initial tranche of \$5 million in baseline funding was included in the FY 2026 Adopted Budget Plan to address significant IT-related needs in areas including Infrastructure Requirements, Cloud Expansion, Application Modernization, Phone System Replacement, as well as new technology and training. Multiple investments are being made with these funds, including filling previously vacant positions to stand up a data and innovation team in DIT with a Chief Director of Innovation, a long-time request of ITPAC.

The FY 2026 funding was always intended to be the first stage of a multi-year effort to address increasing IT requirements and demands. ITPAC supports DIT's request for an additional \$5 million, bringing the overall total to \$10 million, to continue the process of bringing DIT to its optimal state, primarily in the following areas:

- Elevating customer experience as a central pillar by ensuring seamless support, training and service desk functions
- Modernizations and expanding in growth areas such as artificial intelligence, machine learning, data analytics, expanded mobile/web options, and other emerging technologies
- Strengthening governance, vendor management, finance, and program delivery
- Augmenting and streamlining network, cloud, architecture, and data center operations for enhanced operations for enhanced efficiency and scalability
- Developing and promoting agile transformation through developing Centers of Excellence to drive enterprise-wide delivery improvement
- Pursuing additional application modernization and implementing new technologies

Other areas requiring investment include:

Customer Portals: As discussed at the recent Board IT Committee meeting, the long-term vision of *One Account, One Experience* includes developing a single point of access for residents and business, with the goal of transforming the customer experience through digital modernization and data-informed services, while ensuring equitable IT access. This is complex work that will require significant investment and innovation.

Collaboration with Partners for Growth: Collaborate with local entities, such as FCPS or companies with a large local presence, to co-develop services like predictive analytics or "smart/connected communities."

Challenges to Achieving the Mission: ITPAC recommends continuing work to address these longstanding items.

Hiring Impediments with IT Staff Approaching Retirement: DIT struggles to hire and retain the high-level IT talent it requires from the DMV marketplace. Issues include non-competitive compensation, hiring non-responsiveness, limitation on home location and telework restrictions. The business impact of this situation will be felt soon as nearly 25% of DIT staff are in DROP or eligible to retire shortly.

Protection of County Data: The cybersecurity threat landscape is continuously expanding due to advancements in artificial intelligence and cloud technology. Strengthening data governance practices, including robust data protection measures, is essential for maintaining uninterrupted operations, and minimizing risk of data loss. Prioritizing these efforts in budget planning is crucial.

Growing Value of Data Analytics with Data Proliferating: The expansion and increased use of data build with the need for advanced technology to collect, manage, preserve and analyze this data.

Agencies' Business Process Transformations: As agencies strive for greater efficiency through process transformation, their proposals often have significant IT implications. For these initiatives to be effective, DIT must be engaged early as a partner to ensure the proposal is both cost effective and sustainable.

Agility and Time Required to Execute Contracts: The County would greatly benefit from increased contracting agility and faster contract awarding. Current processes often prolong the time required to implement technology, which can lead to higher costs and even prevent implementation entirely.

Additional FY 2027 Recommendation Highlights: ITPAC also supports the following initiatives.

- Continue the innovative multi-budget process investment strategy for major IT projects, allowing timely funding for multi-year projects such as the recently implemented PLUS system, the Human Services Integrative Roadmap and similar major projects.
- Provision of requested funds to support inflationary cost increases and maintain required licenses for technology software and other core systems, as nearly all products and services in the Technology Infrastructure portfolio require annual increases to maintain current service levels. These services are not only necessary to keep the County secure from outside cyber threats, but also to allow the County to be more mobile and keep the network infrastructure, telephony and other related services current with the ever-changing technology landscape.

Conclusion: Similar to other large high-performing organizations, the County's reliance on technology continues to expand. Given the need to protect against constantly evolving cyber threats and the rapid advance in the use of information and technology to deliver services, the County must modernize with the latest technologies and applications to meet its goals. ITPAC appreciates and values the opportunity to assist the County in achieving best practices in technology governance and implementation strategies.

Cc:

Information Technology Policy Advisory Committee

Matthew Harrison, Chief Information Officer

Maura Power, Chief Technology Officer

Christina Jackson, Chief Financial Officer

Ellicia Seard-McCormick, Deputy County Executive for Administration